

Onboarding Checklist for New Hires

Before Day One

IT provisions your laptop and accounts 3 business days before your start date. HR sends your offer packet and I-9 form for e-signature, which must be completed within 3 business days of the start date per federal requirements. New hires also receive a welcome email with parking or transit information for their assigned office, if applicable.

Week One

New hires complete Contoso 101 orientation, benefits enrollment, and meet with their manager to set 30-60-90 day goals. IT security training and the Code of Conduct acknowledgment must also be completed within the first week, and access to systems beyond the basic starter set is granted only after both are confirmed complete.

First 90 Days

Managers conduct check-ins at 30, 60, and 90 days. The first formal performance conversation happens at the 90-day mark, which also marks the end of the introductory period referenced in several other policies (e.g., 401(k) eligibility, parental leave eligibility, and full participation in the Employee Referral Program's eligibility rules).

Buddy Program

Every new hire is assigned a peer buddy from a different team for their first 60 days, to provide an informal point of contact outside the direct reporting line for questions about culture and unwritten norms. Buddies are volunteers who have been at Contoso Corp for at least 1 year, and the buddy relationship is entirely optional to continue past the 60-day period if both people find it useful.

Buddies receive a short onboarding guide of their own, covering common new-hire questions and where to redirect anything outside their own knowledge, so the buddy relationship supplements rather than replaces the manager and HR as the authoritative source for policy questions.

Required Trainings

Beyond Contoso 101 and IT security training, new hires must complete anti-harassment training within their first 30 days and, for people managers specifically, a manager-fundamentals training within their first 90 days covering performance reviews, PTO approvals, and how to handle a conduct concern.

Role-specific compliance training (for example, data-handling training for anyone touching Confidential data) is assigned automatically based on job code and must be completed within 2 weeks of assignment; overdue mandatory training triggers an automated reminder to both the employee and their manager.

Manager Responsibilities

A new hire's manager is responsible for submitting the 30-60-90 day goals to HR, scheduling the check-ins described above, and confirming the new hire has been introduced to their assigned buddy within the first week. Managers who have not completed manager-fundamentals training may not yet approve PTO requests independently; HR co-approves in the interim.

Frequently Asked Questions

What if my laptop hasn't arrived by my start date? Contact the IT Service Desk immediately; a loaner laptop is available for temporary use while your provisioned device is tracked down or replaced, so a shipping delay should never actually block your first day.

Do I need to complete all required trainings before I can start real work? No — trainings have their own deadlines (30 days for anti-harassment, 2 weeks for role-specific compliance training) and are not a prerequisite for beginning normal job responsibilities, except for the specific systems access gated behind Week One's IT security training and Code of Conduct acknowledgment.

Roles and Responsibilities

HR owns the offer packet, I-9 completion, and benefits enrollment. IT owns equipment provisioning and systems access. The hiring manager owns setting 30-60-90 day goals and conducting the scheduled check-ins. The assigned buddy owns informal cultural onboarding support.

Office-Specific Orientation

New hires assigned to an office (as opposed to fully remote) receive a building tour on their first day covering emergency exits, restrooms, the kitchen and coffee area, printer and supply locations, and how badge access works for their specific floor. Employees should keep their badge on them at all times while in the building, since propping doors open or letting an unbadged person in behind them ("tailgating") is a security violation regardless of how well the new hire knows the person.

Remote new hires receive an equivalent virtual orientation covering the same practical topics adapted for a home office context, plus a specific walkthrough of how to request the equipment and home office stipend described in the Remote Work Policy, since remote new hires do not automatically receive equipment the way an office-based new hire's desk is pre-set up.

Feedback on the Onboarding Experience

At the 90-day mark, new hires receive a short onboarding experience survey, separate from their performance conversation, asking specifically about the checklist above: whether equipment arrived on time, whether the buddy program was useful, and whether required trainings were clear. This feedback is reviewed quarterly by People Operations and has directly driven changes to this checklist in the past, including the addition of the loaner-laptop process described in the FAQ above.